中国的三个传统节日

春节·端午节·中秋节

Three Traditional Chinese Festivals

Spring Festival · Dragon Boat Festival · Mid-Autumn Festival

Text and translation by Claude (Anthropic) — a test text for zhbook

Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 4 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 中国有很多传统节日。在这些节日里，人们会和家人在一起，吃特别的食物，做有意思的事情。其中，春节、端午节[†]和中秋节[‡]是最重要的三个节日。它们的日期都按照农历[§]来计算，所以每年在公历[¶]上的日子都不一样。下面我们就来简单介绍一下这三个节日。

春节

2 春节就是中国的新年，是一年中最重要的节日。春节在农历正月[*]初一，一般在公历一月底或者二月。春节以前，很多在外地工作的人都要回老家跟父母一起过年。每年这个时候，火车站和机场里到处都是人，这种现象叫做“春运[#]”。

3 过年以前，人们要打扫房子，因为大家相信，这样可以把旧的一年里不好的东西都扫出去。

† 端午节 *Duānwǔjié* Dragon Boat Festival
‡ 中秋节 *Zhōngqiūjié* Mid-Autumn Festival
§ 农历 *nónglì* lunar calendar
¶ 公历 *gōnglì* Gregorian calendar
* 正月 *zhēngyuè* first lunar month
春运 *chūnyùn* Spring Festival travel rush

China has many traditional festivals. During these festivals, people spend time with their families, eat special food and do interesting things. Among them, the Spring Festival, the Dragon Boat Festival and the Mid-Autumn Festival are the three most important. Their dates are all reckoned by the lunar calendar, so each year they fall on a different day of the Western calendar. Below we give a short introduction to these three festivals. 1

The Spring Festival

The Spring Festival is the Chinese New Year, the most important festival of the year. It falls on the first day of the first lunar month, usually at the end of January or in February. Before the festival, many people who work far from home go back to their hometowns to celebrate the New Year with their parents. At this time every year, train stations and airports are packed with people; this is called "chunyun", the Spring Festival travel rush. 2

Before the New Year, people clean their homes, because they believe this sweeps out everything bad from the old year. 3

然后，人们在门上贴春联[1]和“福”字。有的人会把“福”字倒着贴，因为“倒”和“到”的发音一样，“福倒了”听起来就像“福到了”。

除夕[2]是春节前的最后一个晚上。这天晚上，全家人坐在一起吃年夜饭[3]。在中国北方，很多家庭会一起包饺子；在南方，人们更喜欢吃年糕[4]，因为“年糕”听起来像“年高”，意思是生活一年比一年好。吃完饭以后，很多人会看电视上的春节联欢晚会[5]，一直等到十二点。

新年的第一天，孩子们最高兴，因为他们可以从长辈[6]那里收到红包。红包里面装着压岁钱[7]，红色在中国文化里代表好运[8]。现在，很多人也会在手机上发红包。

1 春联 *chūnlián* Spring Festival couplets
2 除夕 *chúxī* New Year's Eve
3 年夜饭 *niányèfàn* New Year's Eve dinner
4 年糕 *niángāo* New Year rice cake
5 春节联欢晚会 *Chūnjié Liánhuān Wǎnhuì* Spring Festival Gala (on TV)
6 长辈 *zhǎngbèi* elders
7 压岁钱 *yāsuìqián* New Year money for children
8 好运 *hǎoyùn* good luck

Then they paste Spring Festival couplets and the character 福 ("good fortune") on their doors. Some people hang the 福 upside down, because 倒 ("upside down") sounds just like 到 ("to arrive"): "the fortune is upside down" sounds like "good fortune has arrived". 3

Chuxi, New Year's Eve, is the last evening before the Spring Festival. That night the whole family sits down together for the New Year's Eve dinner. In the north of China many families make dumplings together; in the south people prefer niangao, New Year rice cake, because niangao sounds like "higher every year", meaning that life gets better year after year. After dinner many people watch the Spring Festival Gala on television and stay up until midnight. 4

On the first day of the new year the children are the happiest of all, because they receive red envelopes from their elders. Inside the envelopes is "lucky money", and in Chinese culture red stands for good luck. Nowadays many people also send red envelopes on their phones. 5

5 春节期间，人们还会去亲戚[1]朋友家拜年[2]，见面的时候常常说“新年快乐”或者“恭喜发财[3]”。

6 关于春节，有一个很有名的传说。很久以前，有一个叫“年”的怪兽[4]，每到冬天的最后一个晚上就出来伤害人。后来人们发现，年怕红色，也怕很大的声音。所以，人们就在门上贴红纸，晚上放鞭炮[5]。这就是过年习惯的来源之一。春节一直到正月[6]十五的元宵节[7]才结束。那天晚上，人们吃汤圆[8]、看花灯[9]，热热闹闹地结束新年。

端午节[10]

7 端午节在农历[11]五月初五[12]，一般在公历[13]六月。这个节日已经有两千多年的历史了。

1 亲戚 *qīnqi* relatives
2 拜年 *bàinián* to pay a New Year visit
3 恭喜发财 *gōngxǐ fācái* “May you prosper!”
4 怪兽 *guàishòu* monster
5 鞭炮 *biānpào* firecrackers
6 正月 *zhēngyuè* first lunar month
7 元宵节 *Yuánxiāojié* Lantern Festival
8 汤圆 *tāngyuán* sweet rice dumplings
9 花灯 *huādēng* festive lanterns
10 端午节 *Duānwǔjié* Dragon Boat Festival
11 农历 *nónglì* lunar calendar
12 初五 *chūwǔ* fifth day of a lunar month
13 公历 *gōnglì* Gregorian calendar

During the festival people also visit relatives and friends to wish them a happy New Year, greeting them with "Happy New Year!" or "May you prosper!" 5

There is a famous legend about the Spring Festival. Long ago there was a monster called Nian that came out to attack people on the last night of every winter. Later people discovered that Nian was afraid of the colour red and of loud noises. So people pasted red paper on their doors and set off firecrackers at night. This is one of the origins of the New Year customs. The festival season lasts until the Lantern Festival on the fifteenth day of the first month. That evening people eat tangyuan, sweet rice dumplings, and go to see the lanterns, ending the New Year in lively style. 6

The Dragon Boat Festival

The Dragon Boat Festival falls on the fifth day of the fifth lunar month, usually in June. The festival has a history of more than two thousand years. 7

关于端午节[1]的来源，最有名的说法[2]和古代诗人屈原[3]有关[4]。

屈原生活在两千多年前的楚国[5]。他很爱自己的国家，也给国王[6]提了很多好的建议，可是国王不相信他，还让他离开了首都。后来，楚国被别的国家打败了。屈原非常难过，就在五月初五[7]这一天跳进了汨罗江[8]。

当地的人们很尊敬[9]屈原，听到这个消息以后，马上划着船去江上找他。为了不让鱼吃屈原的身体，人们把米饭扔[10]进江里给鱼吃。后来，划船慢慢变成了赛龙舟[11]，把米饭扔进江里也变成了吃粽子[12]的习惯。

今天，赛龙舟是端午节最热闹的活动。

1 端午节 *Duānwǔjié* Dragon Boat Festival
2 说法 *shuōfǎ* version, account
3 屈原 *Qū Yuán* Qu Yuan (c. 340–278 BC), poet and minister of Chu
4 有关 *yǒuguān* to be related to
5 楚国 *Chǔguó* the State of Chu
6 国王 *guówáng* king
7 初五 *chūwǔ* fifth day of a lunar month
8 汨罗江 *Mìluó Jiāng* Miluo River (in Hunan)
9 尊敬 *zūnjìng* to respect
10 扔 *rēng* to throw
11 赛龙舟 *sài lóngzhōu* dragon boat racing
12 粽子 *zòngzi* zongzi, sticky rice wrapped in leaves

The best-known account of its origin is connected with the ancient poet Qu Yuan. 7

Qu Yuan lived more than two thousand years ago in the State of Chu. He loved his country and gave the king a great deal of good advice, but the king did not trust him and even sent him away from the capital. Later, Chu was defeated by another state. Heartbroken, Qu Yuan threw himself into the Miluo River on the fifth day of the fifth month. 8

The local people deeply respected Qu Yuan. When they heard the news, they immediately rowed out onto the river to look for him. To stop the fish from eating Qu Yuan's body, they threw rice into the river for the fish to eat instead. Over time the rowing turned into dragon boat racing, and throwing rice into the river became the custom of eating zongzi. 9

Today, dragon boat racing is the liveliest event of the festival. 10

10 一条龙舟[1]上有十几个或者二十几个人，船头还有一个人打鼓[2]。大家跟着鼓声[3]一起努力划，看哪条船最快。现在，赛龙舟[4]不只在中国有，在世界上很多国家也能看到。

11 粽子[5]是用竹叶[6]把糯米[7]包起来，然后煮[8]熟的。北方人常常吃甜的粽子，里面放红枣[9]或者豆沙；南方人更喜欢咸的粽子，里面有肉或者咸蛋黄[10]。每年端午节[11]，网上都会讨论哪一种粽子更好吃，大家的意见总是不一样。另外，有些地方的人还会在门上挂艾草[12]，人们认为这样可以保护家人的健康。

1 龙舟 *lóngzhōu* dragon boat
2 鼓 *gǔ* drum
3 鼓声 *gǔshēng* drumbeat
4 赛龙舟 *sài lóngzhōu* dragon boat racing
5 粽子 *zòngzi* zongzi, sticky rice wrapped in leaves
6 竹叶 *zhúyè* bamboo leaves
7 糯米 *nuòmǐ* glutinous rice
8 煮 *zhǔ* to boil
9 红枣 *hóngzǎo* red dates, jujubes
10 咸蛋黄 *xiándànhuáng* salted egg yolk
11 端午节 *Duānwǔjié* Dragon Boat Festival
12 艾草 *àicǎo* mugwort

A dragon boat carries a crew of a dozen or twenty-odd people, with a drummer sitting at the bow. Everyone paddles hard together to the beat of the drum, to see which boat is the fastest. Nowadays dragon boat races are held not only in China but in many countries around the world. 10

Zongzi are made by wrapping glutinous rice in bamboo leaves and then boiling it until cooked. Northerners usually eat sweet zongzi filled with red dates or bean paste; southerners prefer savoury ones with meat or salted egg yolk. Every year at the festival people argue online about which kind tastes better, and they never agree. In some places people also hang mugwort on their doors, believing that it protects the family's health. 11

中秋节[1]

12 中秋节在农历[2]八月十五，一般在公历[3]九月或者十月。这一天正好是秋天的中间，所以叫“中秋[4]”。中国人认为，中秋节晚上的月亮是一年中最圆、最亮的。圆圆的月亮代表团圆[5]，所以中秋节也是一个家人团聚[6]的节日。

13 中秋节最有名的传说是嫦娥奔月[7]的故事。很久很久以前，天上有十个太阳，地上非常热，植物都死了，人们的生活很困难。一个叫后羿[8]的英雄[9]用弓箭[10]射[11]下了九个太阳，救了大家。王母娘娘[12]送给他一种药，吃了就能长生不老[13]，还能飞到天上去。

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1 中秋节 *Zhōngqiūjié* Mid-Autumn Festival
2 农历 *nónglì* lunar calendar
3 公历 *gōnglì* Gregorian calendar
4 中秋 *zhōngqiū* mid-autumn
5 团圆 *tuányuán* family reunion
6 团聚 *tuánjù* to gather, to reunite
7 嫦娥奔月 *Cháng'é bēn yuè* “Chang'e Flies to the Moon”
8 后羿 *Hòu Yì* Hou Yi, legendary archer
9 英雄 *yīngxióng* hero
10 弓箭 *gōngjiàn* bow and arrow
11 射 *shè* to shoot
12 王母娘娘 *Wángmǔ Niángniang* the Queen Mother of the West
13 长生不老 *chángshēng bùlǎo* to live forever

The Mid-Autumn Festival

The Mid-Autumn Festival falls on the fifteenth day of the eighth lunar month, usually in September or October. The day falls right in the middle of autumn, hence the name "Mid-Autumn". Chinese people believe that the moon on the night of the festival is the roundest and brightest of the year. The full, round moon stands for reunion, so the Mid-Autumn Festival is also a time for families to come together. 12

The festival's most famous legend is the story of Chang'e flying to the moon. Long, long ago there were ten suns in the sky. The earth was scorching, the plants all died, and life was very hard. A hero named Hou Yi shot down nine of the suns with his bow and arrows and saved everyone. The Queen Mother of the West gave him an elixir: whoever took it would live forever and could fly up to heaven. 13

14 后羿[1]不想离开妻子嫦娥[2]，就把药交给了她。有一天，一个坏人想抢[3]这种药。嫦娥没有办法，只好自己把药吃了下去。她的身体慢慢变轻，飞出了窗户，一直飞到了月亮上。从那以后，后羿每年八月十五都会在院子里放上嫦娥喜欢吃的水果和点心[4]，看着月亮想念她。据说，这就是中秋节[5]拜月[6]习俗[7]的来源。

15 中秋节最重要的食物是月饼[8]。月饼是圆的，和满月一样，也代表团圆[9]。传统的月饼里面有莲蓉[10]、豆沙或者五仁[11]，有的还有咸蛋黄[12]。现在，商店里还能买到冰淇淋[13]月饼、巧克力月饼，口味[14]越来越多。中秋节前，人们常常买月饼送给亲戚[15]、朋友和同事。

1 后羿 *Hòu Yì* Hou Yi, legendary archer
2 嫦娥 *Cháng'é* Chang'e, goddess of the moon
3 抢 *qiǎng* to snatch, to rob
4 点心 *diǎnxin* pastries, snacks
5 中秋节 *Zhōngqiūjié* Mid-Autumn Festival
6 拜月 *bàiyuè* to worship the moon
7 习俗 *xísú* custom
8 月饼 *yuèbǐng* mooncake
9 团圆 *tuányuán* family reunion
10 莲蓉 *liánróng* lotus seed paste
11 五仁 *wǔrén* "five kernels" (mixed nut filling)
12 咸蛋黄 *xiándànhuáng* salted egg yolk
13 冰淇淋 *bīngqílín* ice cream
14 口味 *kǒuwèi* flavour
15 亲戚 *qīnqi* relatives

Hou Yi did not want to leave his wife Chang'e, so he gave the elixir to her. 14
One day a wicked man tried to steal it. With no other way out, Chang'e swallowed the elixir herself. Her body slowly grew lighter; she floated out of the window and flew all the way up to the moon. From then on, every year on the fifteenth of the eighth month, Hou Yi set out the fruit and cakes Chang'e loved in the courtyard and gazed at the moon, missing her. This is said to be the origin of the Mid-Autumn custom of honouring the moon.

The most important food of the festival is the mooncake. Mooncakes are 15
round like the full moon, and they too stand for reunion. Traditional mooncakes are filled with lotus seed paste, bean paste or "five kernels", and some also contain a salted egg yolk. Now the shops also sell ice-cream mooncakes and chocolate mooncakes, and there are more flavours every year. Before the festival, people often buy mooncakes as gifts for relatives, friends and colleagues.

16 中秋节[1]晚上，家人常常坐在院子里或者阳台上，一边吃月饼[2]、喝茶，一边赏月[3]、聊天。有的地方还有提灯笼[4]、猜[5]灯谜[6]的活动。如果家人不在身边，人们也会抬头[7]看着同[8]一个月亮，想念远方[9]的亲人。中国古代的诗人写过很多关于中秋[10]月亮的诗，其中苏轼[11]的一句“但愿[12]人长久[13]，千里共婵娟[14]”到今天还常常被人们引用[15]。

结语

17 春节、端午节[16]和中秋节虽然有不同的故事和习惯，但是它们都有一个共同点：家人团聚[17]。不管人们在哪里，不管工作多忙，到了这些节日，大家都希望能回家，和家人一起吃一顿饭。

1 中秋节 *Zhōngqiūjié* Mid-Autumn Festival
2 月饼 *yuèbǐng* mooncake
3 赏月 *shǎngyuè* to admire the moon
4 灯笼 *dēnglong* lantern
5 猜 *cāi* to guess
6 灯谜 *dēngmí* lantern riddles
7 抬头 *táitóu* to raise one’s head
8 同 *tóng* same
9 远方 *yuǎnfāng* far away
10 中秋 *zhōngqiū* mid-autumn
11 苏轼 *Sū Shì* Su Shi (1037–1101), Song-dynasty poet
12 但愿 *dànyuàn* if only, may
13 长久 *chángjiǔ* for a long time
14 婵娟 *chánjuān* the moon (poetic)
15 引用 *yǐnyòng* to quote
16 端午节 *Duānwǔjié* Dragon Boat Festival
17 团聚 *tuánjù* to gather, to reunite

On the night of the festival, families often sit in the courtyard or on the bal- 16
cony, eating mooncakes and drinking tea while they admire the moon and chat. In some places people also carry lanterns and solve lantern riddles. When family members are far away, people look up at the same moon and think of their loved ones in distant places. Ancient Chinese poets wrote many poems about the Mid-Autumn moon. One line by Su Shi, "May we all live long, and share this lovely moon though a thousand miles apart", is still often quoted today.

In Closing

The Spring Festival, the Dragon Boat Festival and the Mid-Autumn Festival 17
each have their own stories and customs, but they all share one thing: family reunion. Wherever people are and however busy they may be, when these festivals come round everyone hopes to go home and share a meal with their family.

17 这也许就是传统节日到今天还这么重要的原因。

Perhaps this is why the traditional festivals still matter so much today. 17